

Word Stress Assignment
in
Morphologically Simple Words

PREFATORY MATTERS

- English, while historically a Germanic language, is rife with words from Latin and French, owing to the Norman Conquest, and subsequent events pertaining to the history of English.
- The Latinate addendum to English has obfuscated the stress pattern in English words.
- However, patterns can be observed throughout and across lexical categories, and in words that have the same syllable count.
- Monosyllabic words will not be discussed for obvious reasons.
- The native stress pattern in Germanic languages is trochaic (strong-weak)
- Latinate/Romance languages do not have observable stress patterns, since stress is assigned lexically, however, French has a phrase final assignment mechanism (which is of importance here).
- In English, a lot of romance affixes are not considered productive, and therefore, words bearing romance affixes are considered morphologically simple.

BISYLLABIC NOUNS

- Follows native trochaic pattern. Stress is on the penultimate syllable.
- E.g Arab, bigot, carpet → ['ær.əb] ['bɪg.ət] ['kɑ:r.pət]
- Exceptions include (1) nouns which have been borrowed from other languages and are written with a double vowel letter and (2) those borrowed specifically from French and carry French endings.
- (1) balloon, bazaar, canteen
- (2) finesse, gazette, parade, crevasse
- Non-exhaustive set of French endings → { -ee, -ette, -ade, -elle, -esse, -asse, -eur, -euse }
- French origin words that do not bear these endings also exhibit final stress, e.g hotel.

BISYLLABIC ADJECTIVES

- Follows native trochaic pattern. Stress is on the penultimate syllable.
- E.g angry, brilliant, central, crazy, dozy
- The trochaic pattern can also be found in morphologically simple bisyllabic adjectives ending in -ic, as in cosmic, frantic, Nordic, static.
- However, there are bisyllabic adjectives with final stress, such as complete, immense, intense, precise, select.
- The aforementioned bear latinate prefixes.
- Adjectives with French endings, including grotesque and bizarre, also assign stress to the final syllable.

BISYLLABIC VERBS

- Most bisyllabic verbs lay stress of the final syllable. Nouns however, as has been established, follow the native trochaic pattern.
- Verb-noun pairs illustrate the differing stress assignment of the same word when the lexical categories are changed.
- verb–noun pairs con'tract (verb) & `contract (noun), di`gest (verb) & `digest (noun), pro`duce (verb) & `produce (noun), ex`port (verb) & `export (noun), com`pound (verb) & `compound (noun)
- Exceptions include con`cern and `preface, wherein the stress pattern is same despite category change.
- There are, however, bisyllabic verbs with the basic trochaic stress pattern, such as argue, canter, dither, enter, equal
- Verbs ending in -ate, assign stress to the -ate ending, e.g create, deflate, locate.
- **Bisyllabic adverbs** follow the trochaic pattern consistently

POLYSYLLABIC NOUNS

- Follows native trochaic pattern. Primary stress on the antepenultimate syllable.
- E.g academy, antelope, camera, elephant, harmony → [ə'kæd.ə.mi] ['æn.tɪ.ləʊp]
['kæm.ər.ə]
- Exceptions include (1) nouns with final syllables written with a double vowel letter and (2) those borrowed from French bearing French endings.
- (1) kangaroo (2) cigarette, lemonade, bagatelle, picturesque, connoisseur
- Nouns with a consonant cluster after the penultimate vowel take penultimate stress instead, e.g advantage, apartment, consensus, disaster.
- Nouns ending in -ics also take penultimate stress, e.g acoustics, linguistics, mathematics, statistics.
- A further set of loanwords ending in a vowel depart from the antepenultimate pattern and take penultimate stress, e.g banana, mosquito, potato, volcano.

POLYSYLLABIC ADJECTIVES

- Follows native trochaic pattern. Primary stress on the antepenultimate syllable.
- E.g general, intelligent, juvenile, taciturn
- Adjectives with a consonant cluster after the penultimate vowel take penultimate stress, e.g dependent, disastrous, indulgent, momentous, tremendous.
- This includes words with an 'rC' cluster, e.g enormous, maternal.
- Polysyllabic adjectives ending in -ate consistently follow the antepenultimate pattern, e.g deliberate, fortunate, legitimate.
- This contrasts with bisyllabic verbs ending in -ate, which assign stress to the -ate ending.

POLYSYLLABIC VERBS

- As with bisyllabic verbs, polysyllabic verbs frequently depart from the basic trochaic pattern.
- Many assign primary stress to the final syllable, e.g entertain, intervene, intersect.
- Many of these bear Latinate prefixes, e.g enter-, inter-.
- Unlike bisyllabic verbs ending in -ate, polysyllabic verbs ending in -ate follow the antepenultimate pattern, e.g co-ordinate, elaborate, investigate, originate.
- This mirrors the behaviour of polysyllabic adjectives ending in -ate (deliberate, fortunate), making -ate a reliable predictor of antepenultimate stress in words of three or more syllables regardless of category.